

Title: What Low Elo Is Really Like: An In-Depth Analysis

Score:

--- POST CONTENT ---

0. Sections for Quick Reference

1. This Sub's Perspective on Low Elo

2. What Really Makes Low Elo Players "Bad"

3. Mechanics and Fighting

4. Wave Management and Laning

5. Low Elo Has No Macro

6. The Famed "Silver Skill Variance"

7. Smurfs Ruining Low Elo

8. Teammates Feeding Harder Than I Can Get Fed

9. TLDR and Questions

1. This Sub's Perspective on Low Elo

Low Elo is a mysterious place, I've seen many posts on this sub about it and I've had my own

ideas about it, but often people say strange things about it that I have trouble believing. A very common one is the opinion that [?low elo can actually be hard(er than high elo) because the games are so random.?(https://old.reddit.com/r/summonerschool/comments/12hfr13/why_does_silver_feel_harder_than_gold_what_am_i/jfonnj1/)] Another take that I see is [?low elo players actually have good mechanics now, low elo OTPs can easily coinflip win lane against D+ players?](https://old.reddit.com/r/summonerschool/comments/12hfr13/why_does_silver_feel_harder_than_gold_what_am_i/jg4j5ud/) or related takes like [?a bronze 2 player would get high gold back in S4?](https://old.reddit.com/r/summonerschool/comments/12me7s4/i_have_never_been_bronze_in_4_years_but_now_i_may/jgarn6v/) (I can't believe you guys downvoted the guy rightfully calling this out as complete cap, I was Plat in S4 and let me tell you it was nothing like Bronze today).

So, for the first time in my life I decided to actually play in low elo and see what it was like. I bought an Iron 4 account, and climbed to gold MMR. I spent about 10 games in each division's MMR, at this point the account is about to hit plat MMR. [Account for reference.](<https://www.op.gg/summoners/na/reddit%20copium>) I did end up losing twice, both times to my teammates surrendering pre-20 (I believe I could've carried both games, but we will never know). Here are my observations on what low elo is actually like:

2. What Really Makes Low Elo Players "Bad?"

Low elo players struggle with everything to be honest, but there were two very obvious (and more easily fixable) things. These main issues I saw low elo players having were 1. fighting badly due to bad cooldown usage and 2. not being able to maintain leads or stop enemy snowball because they would fight all the time.

Low elo players seem to have no thought for what their cooldowns should actually be used for, and even if they can aim their spells, they will never be using them at the right time. This makes them seem mechanically much worse than a higher elo player even though many people think of ?mechanics? as purely aim and comboing. Lucians would be dashing at me for DPS, Supports used CC aggressively instead of defensively, and Mages would use their self-peel for extra damage. Even players with >200 games on the champion they were playing would do this sort of thing.

Low elo players also take every fight whether it?s winning or losing. My lane opponents also rarely conceded the lane once I started to snowball, and would instead continue to trade with me despite it never working. By extension, players would stop farming part-way through the game to instead roam around the map looking for random bloodbaths.

I think that low elo players could improve their play a lot by thinking about when your champion really needs to use its large cooldowns, and holding them for when you need them. Also, stop fighting over everything. Seriously, stop fighting. If you have a lead you will naturally push it by threatening objectives when they?re up. You don?t need to fight. Stop fighting.

3. Mechanics and Fighting

There?s a pervasive idea that players have gotten so much better over the years that even a low elo player has a mechanical mastery of their best champions. However, I think this doesn?t take into account some major aspects of mechanics that low elo players struggle with: spacing and spell timing. Just because you can *aim* a spell doesn?t mean you can *hit* the spell. Better players will time their spell usages when the enemy is in another animation or otherwise distracted, and also have a better idea of where they and their opponent need to be to threaten certain spells.

Even though I didn't see many silver players completely whiffing their abilities, I still got hit by very few spells in lane because the enemy would just use them at a time when they were easy for me to dodge. They also spaced very badly in lane and teamfights, which exacerbated the problem and caused everyone to line up quite nicely to get hit by all of my abilities. As mentioned earlier, there additionally seemed to be no thought put into when players would use their spells and important cooldowns.

Speaking of cooldowns, low elo players don't cooldown track beyond summoner spells and (sometimes) ults. I never saw players get punished for dropping major cooldowns like Fio W or Syndra E. This also caused a lot of low elo players to have the bad habit of just dropping huge CDs in lane and then continuing to trade, letting me kill them for free. For instance, if Jax E is down in lane, he cannot approach wave without losing most of his HP. But low elo players would use Jax E in a trade, then immediately go back to trying to farm in front of me.

Overall, low elo fighting is still very bad (whether you consider this "mechanics" or not is semantic), but not really because "they can't aim their spells." Rather, the lack of positioning, fight awareness, and game knowledge is so lacking in low elo that players will fight extremely sub-optimally even if they land all of their abilities.

4. Wave Management and Laning

There's another frequent comment on this sub that "Low elo players can freeze now! They know wave management exists!?" What they aren't telling you is that low elo players can only freeze. That's the only wave management they know, and they never do it well. I would bounce, pull, stack waves and dive over and over and over, and the enemy players never once caught on to what I was

doing. Players would pull 4 waves and then be surprised when I 1v2d them and their jungler on the gank. They backed when they were low, never looking for good back timings, and even when they did manage to pull a freeze would be easily baited into breaking it by me trading in wave. Nobody paid attention to wavestates when rotating or going for objectives either, farm was just sacrificed constantly to fuel the low elo need to fight all the time.

Low elo players are (still) very bad at laning due to making no attempt to get wave control, and previously mentioned mechanical issues. I took extremely greedy scaling runes and summoners (conditioning + demolish + overgrowth, triumph, flash + ghost) every game which provided minimal lane advantage (for reference, in high elo I always go biscuits and often go bone plating or second wind, as well as bringing TP). I also would often rush Tear + Cull to further hamper my early game. I failed to win one lane the entire time. This failure was due to very bad luck, where the enemy Aatrox accidentally interrupted my W mid-dash causing me to die in a pulled wave and get behind. I recovered with a solo kill but left the lane even overall.

5. Low Elo Has No Macro

Low elo indeed has no macro, and people just fight all the time. If I could give any advice to low elo players, it would be: stop fucking fighting. Holy shit, stop fighting. I would have lost so many games if the enemy team just stopped fighting me. But I think that this is actually a benefit to someone trying to climb. If you have good laning fundamentals and can consistently win lane (something many, many, many low elo players posting on this sub claim they do?they wouldn't lie, would they?), you should be able to take advantage of the perma-fighting. Your gold advantage will be a constant boon, because people will try to fight you all the time.

6. The Famed "Silver Skill Variance"

Another frequently repeated thing on this sub is that lower elo have more "skill variance" between players. I really didn't find this to be the case. My opponents and teammates got consistently better as I climbed, and I never saw someone who was playing particularly well or badly in the context of their elo. Even fed silver players would continue to play like silvers. Most of the lane stomps I saw came from players just losing coinflip fights early and getting snowballed on, or invades gone bad resulting in one lane starting out behind and getting further snowballed.

Winrates and games played remained relatively stable with most players having a couple hundred games and around a 50% winrate. Players would tilt or make really bad-looking plays but this happens at every single elo, it's not that "some silver players belong in plat and others in iron."

7. Smurfs Ruining Low Elo

This is the first time I've smurfed in low elo, and I found it a profoundly boring and depressing experience. I told myself I was going to get to gold visual rank but I really have no desire to do so...I can't imagine why any high elo player would want to play down here. It was very unengaging, and even when my teammates were all behind it felt like I didn't have to try very hard to win or vary my gameplan at all.

That said, across 40 games I didn't play against anyone else as good as me. I played against three 70%ish winrate players (one on Yorick, one on Nunu, one on Samira) but rolled them over quite easily, I would estimate they were platinum at best. I got one 100% winrate Talon jungle player against me, but their duo abandoned the game to force a remake. I guess they were afraid I would ruin their winrate. Overall I saw another smurf about one in every ten games, more than I expected to be honest but less than this sub would say.

8. Teammates Feeding Harder Than I Can Get Fed

I had many games where the enemy team would get ahead of me in gold because my teammates fed faster than I could get fed. However, I would say that these games are still recoverable if you simply refuse to play as riskily as the enemy fed player (see also: stop fucking fighting). Low elo players will throw their lead, as long as you don't throw yours and just wait for them to do so, you'll be fine. I averaged slightly more than one death per game, and this really only rose above 1/game when I got to gold MMR and needed to sacrifice myself sometimes to avoid losing the game. This is because I would just run away from anything I would lose. Even if I was insanely fed, if four players came, I was out of there. I wouldn't go for the 2v4 dragon contests and 1v5 baron steals. Fed enemy players were bound and determined to carry every single fight and would inevitably eventually take a bad one and lose their lead (and the game).

A few notable games where one in silver where enemy Lucian left lane 10/0 with a Milio support, one where enemy Jinx left lane 7/0 with a Thresh, one where a Vayne left lane 7/0 with a Renata, and one where my team was combined 2-20 (2 kills being my solo kills toplane) at 15 minutes. All of these games were actually quite easy, with the enemy players feeding me their shutdowns randomly taking meaningless fights until I snowballed past them. The hardest games were the rare games where the enemy team simply refused to interact with me and tried to fight me as little as possible, with the game closest to a legitimate loss being one where the enemy team 1-3-1'd the entire game (running away from me whenever I showed in a lane) while my entire team fed. I lost both sidelane inhibitors, but then they grouped mid as 5, I carried the 5v5, and we ended.

9. TL;DR For the love of god, stop fighting.

Open to any additional questions about low elo, though I'm not planning on returning to the account.

--- TOP COMMENTS ---

[Comment 1 | Score: 329]

I feel at least happy knowing that my yelling at the screen for people to stop fighting is justified

[Comment 2 | Score: 89]

Slightly off topic but i find the term low elo always fascinating. Low elo isnt actually low elo but its anything that is not high elo. Like medium or middle elo doesnt exist. Silver and even gold are generally considered low elo while if you are in high silver you are in the top 50% of the ranked player base.